

World in Brief: Iran says deal with Oman “very close”; Typhoon Dolphin hits China



Photograph: Anadolu via Getty Images

Iran's foreign minister said a pact with Oman to establish a [shipping route](#) through the **Strait of Hormuz** was “very close”, but ruled out direct talks with America for now, alleging violations to the interim peace agreement signed in June. Iran also shook up its highest decision-making body on national defence, promoting a hard-line ex-commander of the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps to be its top security official.

More than a million people have been evacuated from their homes in eastern **China** as Typhoon Dolphin made landfall. Torrential rain and winds of up to 150kph triggered warnings of floods and landslides. Transport was widely disrupted, with 1,500 flights cancelled in Shanghai alone. The storm had already swept through the Japanese prefecture of Okinawa, cutting off power to more than 50,000 buildings.

Daniel Kinahan, one of the world's most wanted men, appeared in a Dublin court after being extradited from Dubai. The Irishman is alleged to be the head of a large crime syndicate. He was arrested in the **UAE** in April. In 2022, America's State Department offered a \$5m reward for information on Mr Kinahan and his relatives. It accused them of narcotics trafficking and murder.

The Houthis launched a [drone attack on Saudi Aramco's](#) Jazan refinery on the Red Sea, setting it ablaze. The Iran-backed Yemeni militia had declared a naval blockade [on Saudi Arabia](#) in July. The attack comes two days after Pakistan, Saudi Arabia and Turkey signed a military pact. The Houthis also bombed a residential area near Mokha, a Yemeni port city run by Saudi-backed authorities, reportedly killing seven.

Israel rejected America's [latest peace proposal for Gaza](#). Binyamin Netanyahu, Israel's prime minister, told his cabinet that the army would not withdraw from Gaza—where it occupies more than half of the strip—until Hamas was “genuinely disarmed”, including “heavy weapons, less-heavy weapons, all weapons”. The 15-point peace plan, which Donald Trump said included Hamas's “complete disarmament”, was announced on July 30th.

Factory-gate prices in **China** grew at a slower pace than expected in July. The country's [producer-price index](#) rose by 3.5% year on year, down from 4.1% the month before. Consumer prices, meanwhile, rose by 0.5% over the same period, the smallest increase since January. Lower domestic oil prices helped to curtail both measures.

Harry Potter fans succeeded in getting a new £430m (\$580m) power line rerouted because it originally ran over the “grave” of Dobby, a house elf. Muggles built a shrine to the wizard's diminutive companion on a beach in Wales, on the site where his death was filmed. The energy project's boss admitted he had taken some persuading of the significance of the pile of painted pebbles. Expelliarmus!

Figure of the day: 300,000. The approximate number of industrial robots installed in China in 2024—more than half the world's total that year. But the country is now [worried about displacing its workers](#) by tech.

Have you been following the headlines? Test your knowledge of the news with [our weekly quiz](#).

Ukraine remains vulnerable to Russian missiles

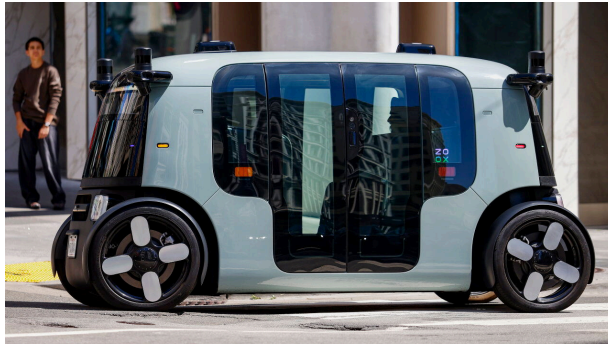


Photograph: AP

In many ways the war is going better for Ukraine. Its strikes deep over the border are bringing the conflict home to Russians. It is also improving recruitment while pioneering new tactics. But Russia's ballistic missiles still pose an existential threat. Last month it launched a record 126 missiles at Ukraine, whose stocks of Patriot interceptors are exhausted. America has used so many in its war against Iran that it is reluctant to sell any more.

Volodymyr Zelensky, Ukraine's president, has begged other countries to loan 300 interceptors to help his country survive the winter. Ukraine and its European allies are also developing a cheaper alternative to the Patriot, though it could be years before that is ready. This week Mr Zelensky said Ukraine would develop its own ballistic and anti-ballistic systems within a year, and that it will continue to target Russian launchers and missile factories. But, for now, Russia's ballistic missiles remain a threat to which it has no real answer.

Amazon's Robotaxis rev up



Photograph: Getty Images

Amazon's Zoox [robotaxis](#) have carried members of the public around Las Vegas and San Francisco for almost a year free of charge, as part of a testing programme. The cartoonish cabs, which have no steering wheel or pedals, are unlike any other car on the road. With an identical front and back (they can drive in either direction), they recall Doctor Dolittle's pushmi-pullyu. From Monday Zoox will start charging Las Vegas passengers a fare

Zoox lags behind Waymo, Google's service, which already charges for rides in more than ten American cities and is expanding abroad. But tech companies are betting that the market for self-driving technology will prove to be vast. Americans already spend around \$50bn a year on ride-hailing services. Then there is the possibility of selling self-driving software to carmakers and manufacturers of other vehicles, such as delivery vans. Soon robots may rule the roads.

The value of Trump's Truth



Photograph: AP

Donald Trump's posts on Truth Social, his social-media platform, frequently move financial markets. Now the platform is trying to cash in. Last week [Trump Media & Technology Group](#), the site's parent in which Mr Trump has a stake of roughly 41%, launched "Truth API", a paid service giving traders and investors faster access to the "most influential accounts". The company has reportedly suggested charging customers up to \$100,000 a month. Critics allege insider trading; the White House has denied a conflict of interest. Trump Media says the product offers "a new long-term recurring revenue stream".

The company, which reports second-quarter earnings on Monday, needs it. Its share price has fallen around 40% in the past year; in the first quarter it posted revenues shy of \$900,000 and net losses of almost \$406m. With ventures in cryptocurrency and streaming seemingly yet to pay off, Kevin McGurn, Trump Media's interim boss, is placing his bets on the value of the president's penmanship—assuming regulators don't clamp down first.

Labour's drilling headache



Photograph: Alamy

On Monday Britain closes public consultation on Jackdaw. The planned [North Sea gasfield](#) (and the larger Rosebank oilfield) is an early test of Andy Burnham's climate credentials. The fossil-fuel industry, some trade unions and right-wing politicians would all like to see their new prime minister move the controversial projects along. Mr Burnham promised Donald Trump that he'll take a "pragmatic approach" to fuel production in British waters.

Daily quiz



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to [\[email protected\]](#). We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Monday: Which British political party, founded in 1900, produced prime ministers such as Ramsay MacDonald and Harold Wilson?

*Older men declare war. But it is
youth that must fight and die.*

Herbert Hoover